

had mistakenly tagged a photo of an African-American couple as ‘gorillas’. Both were rightly chastised. Siri also had a protracted controversy about women’s hygiene and abortion. The NYT later revealed that it was more to do with Siri’s lack of understanding than with Apple’s stance on women’s issues. However, new stuff keeps popping up. For instance, apparently Siri can find the escort services closest to you, can locate the nearest marijuana store, and can help you dispose off a body but can’t understand the terms “IUD’s” or “contraceptives”.

The word ‘inevitable’ should just be repeated over and over when such issues come to light, as it is a self-taught program that is trying to navigate the complex geopolitical issues that even human beings can’t fully wrap their heads around.

The Ultimate Question

In 2001: A Space Odyssey, HAL 9000 tries to take some bad decisions based on what it believes is the greater good. The countless Terminator movies talk about Skynet – a systematic overhaul of society by machines – leading to an apocalypse. Pop culture is full of references to an AI-based doomsday, yet the closest parallel to Siri is in Spike Jonze’s *Her*, where the protagonist ends up falling for his customised voice assistant. The voice assistant is very much like an advanced Siri with her subtle wit and deeply human empathy. The film investigates our ability to find emotion in a complex organism, despite knowing that it is made up of Os and 1s. Perhaps the ultimate voice assistant will be the one that allows the user to fall in love with it.

Or perhaps it is another technological rabbit-hole, a bubble that will burst as soon as the next big thing surfaces. Who can tell, really. Perhaps 50 years from now, if we use voice assistants with the same regularity that we use instant messaging apps in the present, we will ascertain Siri to be the start of something special. Up until then though, we will have to wait and see. **d**